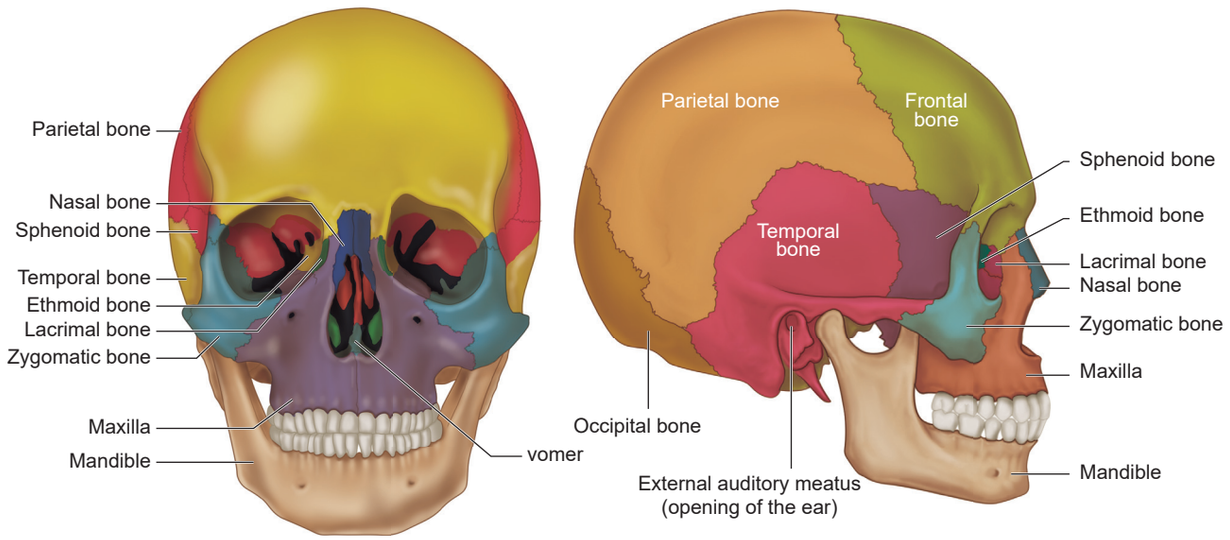


Figure 9. 5 Structure of the skull

b) The Vertebral Column

Vertebral column is also called the back bone. It consists of 33 serially arranged vertebrae which are interc onnected by cartilage known as intervertebral disc (Figure 9.6). The vertebral column extends from the base of the skull to the pelvis and forms the main frame work of the trunk. The vertebral column has five major regions. They are, **the Cervical**, **Thoracic**, **Lumbar**, **Sacrum** (5 sacral vertebrae found in the infant which are fused to form one bone in the adult) and **Coccyx** (4 coccygeal vertebrae found in the infant which are fused to form one bone in the adult).

Each vertebra has a central hollow portion, the neural canal, through which the spinal cord passes. The first vertebra is called as **the atlas** and the second vertebra is called as **the axis**. Atlas is articulated with the occipital condyles.

The vertebral column protects the spinal cord, supports the head and serves as the point of attachment for the ribs and musculature of the back.

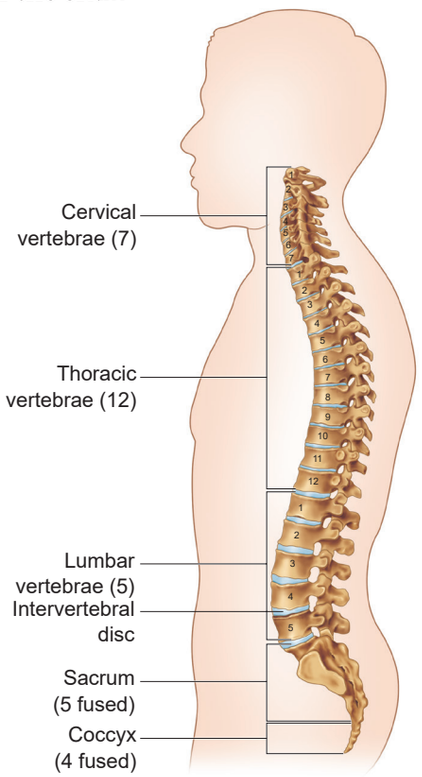


Figure 9. 6 Vertebral Column

(c) The Sternum (Chest bone)

Sternum is a flat bone on the mid ventral line of the thorax. It provides space for the attachment of the thoracic ribs and abdominal muscles.

(d) The Rib cage

There are 12 pairs of ribs (Figure 9.7). Each rib is a thin flat bone connected dorsally to

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